



THE UK AND IRELAND

The Republic of Ireland, also called Éire, is an independent country, with its own government and traditions. England, Scotland, Wales, and Northern Ireland make up the United Kingdom. Many aspects of British life, such as its historical buildings and customs, have been preserved. But the United Kingdom is also good at adapting to change. A rich variety of ethnic groups now live in the United Kingdom's multicultural society.

Democratic center

The Houses of Parliament in London have been the home of British democracy since 1512. The political party with the most representatives, called MPs, forms the government. MPs are voted in at national general elections.



Howzat!

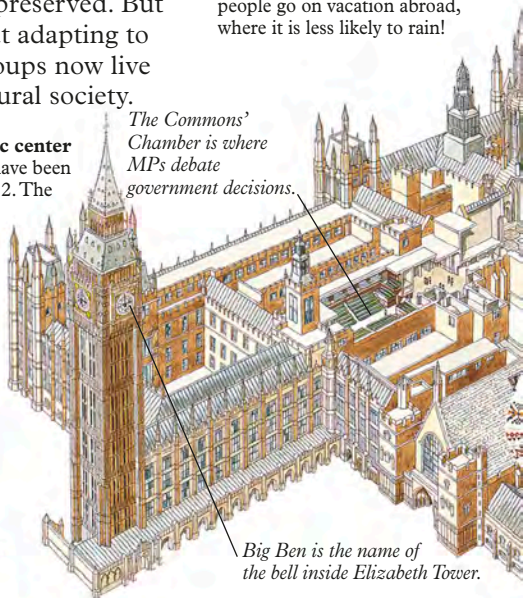
Sunday afternoons in summer would not be the same in many English villages without the familiar sight of a cricket match on the village green. Cricket is an English invention, and is usually followed by another well-known English tradition, afternoon tea!



By the sea

Britain is surrounded by the sea. British seaside vacations first became popular in the 19th century. Today, many British people go on vacation abroad, where it is less likely to rain!

*The Commons'
Chamber is where
MPs debate
government decisions.*



*Big Ben is the name of
the bell inside Elizabeth Tower.*

Guy Fawkes night

A plot to blow up the Houses of Parliament almost succeeded in 1605, but the ringleader, Guy Fawkes, was caught and executed. Guy Fawkes Night is still celebrated all over Britain on November 5, when homemade straw dummies—called guys—are burned on big bonfires at firework parties.

